

DATA & SOCIETY



The Shape of Civic Data

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What a dataset remembers

Section 01

This section of The Shape of Civic Data examines how institutions make choices under pressure. It follows the practical signals that people use to decide whether a public system is understandable, reliable and worthy of trust.

The evidence suggests that good policy is not only a matter of intent. It is also shaped by the routes people take through services, the language used at moments of uncertainty and the visibility of responsibility when something goes wrong.

A useful reader keeps the document itself at the centre. Navigation should be close at hand, search should be predictable and the interface should recede when attention returns to the page.

For data & society, the central design question is how to make collective choices legible without flattening their complexity. The answer begins with careful definitions, open evidence and room for revision.

Public value

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The limits of measurement

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